SPARSHA JAIN

PhD Research Scholar | Menstrual Health, Health Communication & Policy

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RESEARCH PROFILE

Doctoral researcher at the Manipal Institute of Communication, Manipal Academy of Higher Education (MAHE), studying adolescent menstrual health through communication, behavioural practices, school water, sanitation and hygiene (WASH) infrastructure, and policy implementation. Research experience encompasses mixed-methods enquiry, systematic literature synthesis, content analysis, and secondary data analysis, with additional experience in teaching, academic conference organisation, and community-based menstrual-health education.

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Menstrual health and hygiene management • Adolescent health • Health and gender communication • School WASH systems • Gender equity • Policy implementation • Health education and behaviour • Mixed-methods research

EDUCATION & RESEARCH TRAINING

PhD in Media Communication 2024–present

Manipal Institute of Communication, Manipal Academy of Higher Education (MAHE), Manipal, India | Expected completion: 2027

Pre-Doctoral Fellowship 2024

Indian Institute of Management Bangalore (IIMB), Bengaluru, India

Master's in Media Communication 2022

Manipal Academy of Higher Education (MAHE), Manipal, India | CGPA: 8.95/10

BCom (Honours), Commerce 2020

Indian Institute of Management and Commerce, Hyderabad, India | CGPA: 9.04/10

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

Published | Jain, S., & Naik, M. G. (2026). School-based WASH facilities and menstrual hygiene management: a systematic review of impacts on adolescent girls in South Asia, Sub-Saharan Africa, and Southeast Asia. *BMC Women's Health*. https://doi.org/10.1186/s12905-026-04796-2

Accepted for publication | Beyond Product Distribution: School-Based Menstrual Health Policy Implementation and WASH Systems in Karnataka, India. *Journal of Water, Sanitation and Hygiene for Development*.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Doctoral research: Communication, Practice and Policy: A Comprehensive Study on Menstrual Hygiene Among School Girls May 2024–present

Research Scholar, Manipal Institute of Communication, MAHE | Guide: Dr Manjushree Naik; Co-guide: Dr Arpan Yagnik

- Examining menstrual-hygiene awareness, attitudes, and practices among adolescent schoolgirls and the communication environments that shape them.
- Evaluating school and health-authority education strategies, menstrual-health policy initiatives, and WASH-related implementation gaps.
- Employing qualitative and quantitative approaches to link communication, practices, and policy, with reference to SDGs 5 and 6.

Spousal Violence and Human Rights in Karnataka: An Analysis of NFHS-5 Data Feb–Jun 2024

Research Scholar, Manipal Institute of Communication, MAHE | Collaborator: Dr Manjushree Naik

- Analysed NFHS-5 data on gender-based violence in Karnataka and developed comparative visualisations.
- Reviewed responses by local NGOs and identified approaches relevant to rights awareness and support.

Beyond Humor: Recognizing Ageism in Memes on Facebook in India Oct 2023–Feb 2024

Research Fellow Scholar, Department of Public Policy, IIM Bangalore | Collaborator: Dr Allen P. Ugargol

- Conducted content analysis of Facebook memes, identifying age-related stereotypes and the interaction between online humour and cultural perceptions of older adults.
- Examined the potential of digital portrayals to reinforce ageism and considered limitations and directions for comparative research.

Role of Communication in Awareness of Menstrual Hygiene in Adolescents in Udupi Jun–Dec 2022

Master's research, MAHE, Manipal | Supervisor: Dr Manjushree Naik

- Studied how interpersonal and family communication relate to menstrual-health awareness among adolescents in Udupi using a mixed-methods approach.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Guest Faculty – Manipal Institute of Communication, MAHE Jul 2024–Apr 2025

- Basics of Public Policy (Jan–Apr 2025): taught policy analysis through case studies, policy briefs, and a mock parliamentary debate.
- Basics of Knowledge Society (Jan–Apr 2025): taught information-society frameworks and facilitated discussions on media, society, and governance.
- Gender and Communication (Jul–Dec 2024): taught gender stereotyping, patriarchy, and the role of women in development using applied case studies.
- Fundamentals of Internet and New Media (Jul–Dec 2024): incorporated digital advertising, blogging, podcasting, and SEO activities into instruction.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

2025 | "Communication, Practice, and Policy: A Comprehensive Study on Menstrual Hygiene Among School Girls in Karnataka." National Conference on Gender Equity: A Must for Sustainable Development, Mangalore, India (February).

2024 | "Spousal Violence and Human Rights in Karnataka: An Analysis of NFHS-5 Data." 74th International Communication Association Conference, Manipal Regional Hub, MAHE, India (June).

2024 | "Beyond Humour: Recognizing Ageism in Memes on Facebook in India." Karvan e Fikr, Department of Sociology, Jamia Millia Islamia, New Delhi, India (February).

2023 | "Role of Communication in Awareness of Menstrual Hygiene in Adolescents in Udupi." 73rd International Communication Association Conference, Manipal Regional Hub, MAHE, India (May).

2023 | "Role of Communication in Awareness of Menstrual Hygiene in Adolescents in Udupi." Manipal Research Colloquium, MAHE, Manipal, India (April; Best Presenter Award).

ACADEMIC SERVICE & LEADERSHIP

Core Organising Member – International Communication Association event, Manipal 2025

- Coordinated programme development, speaker outreach, event communications, creative assets, and on-site execution.

Conference Organiser – ICA Manipal Regional Hub 2024

- Contributed to conceptualisation and organisation of the regional conference event.

Volunteer – XIX International Conference on Public Policy & Management, IIM Bangalore 2024

- Supported conference theme/content planning, logistics, delegate registration, and session coordination.

FELLOWSHIPS, AWARDS & DISTINCTIONS

- Women@Dior & UNESCO Mentorship & Education Program, 2026–27 – selected mentee; participating in leadership learning on inclusion, sustainability, and creative leadership.
- Best Presenter Award – Manipal Research Colloquium, 2023, for presentation on menstrual-health communication in Udupi.
- Best Student in Print Media – Manipal Institute of Communication, 2023.
- Best Contributor to AM Plus (MAMC) – Manipal Institute of Communication, 2023.
- First Prize – National-level Mecharena 2K18 Advertising Competition; Second Prize – Prerana 2018 State-level Advertising Competition.

COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT & APPLIED COMMUNICATION

Founder & Programme Lead – PadSquad, India Apr 2020–Jun 2021

- Founded a menstrual-health initiative serving underserved communities, including government schools, urban settlements, and tribal communities.
- Coordinated donation drives distributing 1,000+ sanitary pads; led educational workshops reaching 500+ students.
- Mobilised 30+ volunteers, worked with schools and local health stakeholders, and used storytelling campaigns to promote menstrual-health awareness.

Marketing Strategist – Himalayan Ecotourism Jun–Aug 2022

- Developed digital content and marketing initiatives associated with reported increases of 500% in reach and 750% in impressions.
- Coordinated the “Kitaben aur Vadiyan” environmental education project in Pekhri village, including learning resources and field documentation.

TRAINING & PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

- Workshop on Gender Sensitivity, Population First / Manipal Institute of Communication / UNFPA (August 2024).
- International Communication Association India Chapter Emerging Scholars Network, Manipal (June 2024).
- Workshop on integrating generative AI in modern academia (December 2024).
- Swachh Bharat Internship Programme: solid and liquid waste management awareness and school counselling, Telangana.

RESEARCH METHODS & RELEVANT COMPETENCIES

Mixed-methods research • Qualitative and quantitative analysis • Content analysis • Secondary data analysis (NFHS-5) • Systematic literature review and synthesis • Health and policy communication • Scholarly writing and presentation • Teaching and workshop facilitation

ADDITIONAL SCHOLARLY & CREATIVE CONTRIBUTIONS

Author of Khayal, a poetry collection published by Notion Press; editor and contributor to AM Plus newspaper; developed a self-help podcast featuring student experiences at MAHE.